

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

An Enduring Advent ~ Hope

30 November 2025

Advent 1



Bethlehem Star 1 © 2018 Virginia Wieringa, virginiawieringa.com Used by permission

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on THE FIRST NOEL and STUTTGART

Meditation on VENI EMMANUEL

"Prière" and "Vieux Noël" from *L'Organiste* (César Franck) and Improvisation

Sanctus from *The Mass* (Patrick Cassidy) and Improvisation

Et Exspecto (Peter Michael Hammel, arr. C. Bull)

WACHET AUF, RUFT UNS DIE STIMME (Karl Karow)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome & Lighting of the Advent Wreath

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin & Emily Kang

Advent Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Emily Kang

The Hope of God-with-Us does not arrive as guaranteed outcome,
or predetermined plan, or promise of our desired endings.
Hope cannot be imposed from on high. Hope cannot be commanded.

The Hope of God-with-Us is
courageous, risky, unfolding, indeterminate.

The Hope of God-with-Us is
collective, liberating us from deadly complacency.
Hope is gestating in darkness; it comes unexpectedly.
Hope invites our expectation and our participation.

So, our voices cry out:

Prepare the way for hope with courage!

May Hope be birthed among, within, and through us, this Advent.

O Come, O Come, Emmanuel!

-adapted from enfleshed

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Advent Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

O Come, O Come, Emmanuel

VENI EMMANUEL

O Come, O Come, Emmanuel
Make true the stories prophets tell -
So all those chained by fear find release
And, war forgotten, brings a world of peace.
Rejoice! Rejoice! Emmanuel
Is come to birth where all God's children dwell.

O Come, Love's season, to our lonely days,
And guide us in our words and ways
To be the ones whose Advent begins
With healing earth and all that live within.
Rejoice! Rejoice! Emmanuel
Is come to birth where all God's children dwell.

O Come, Desire of Nations, bind
All peoples in one heart and mind;
Make envy, strife, and quarrels cease;
Fill the whole world with heaven's peace.
Rejoice! Rejoice! Emmanuel
Is come to birth where all God's children dwell.

-lyrics by M. Tirabassi

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Holy One of Advent Hope,
we gather in the midst of this time of unknowing,
grateful to understand deep within our hearts
that you forever go before us, preparing new pathways of hope.

In this place, where confidence and hope shine so brightly,
even in the midst of fear and uncertainty,
we know there is room for each and every one of us
to gather in safety and strength.

On this day, help us to remember the Hope that creates light,
a light that shines in the deepest nights as it brings
your peace, joy, and love to us and to our world.

*In this Advent season,
surround us with the gifts of your Spirit, Holy One,
both on this day and in all of the days to come,
so that we may kindle hope anew.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Come Unto Me"

BERNICE JOHNSON REAGON

Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, and Christin Byrdson, Soloists

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sonnie Swenston

*Emmanuel, God-with-us,
Your name is beyond all naming.
May the gentleness of your loving reign take root upon earth;
May your heart's own longings unfold within us
and within all who wait for you in hope.*

*Sustain us, moment by moment,
with the strength to endure in our waiting.
Forgive us when we falter or wound,
and grant us grace to forgive
all those whose wounding has hindered our lives.*

*Spare us trials heavier than we can bear;
yet, in your tender mercy,
journey beside us through the sacred shadows of this season.*

*For in you rests the fullness of creation,
its illuminating light, holy power, and persistent love,
now, and forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

May this time together renew our hope.
May the stories we share refresh our courage,
and the songs we sing, lift our spirits.
May the sound of laughter,
and the sight of faces new and familiar,
restore us in faith. [CODame]

On this first Sunday of Advent, may the hope and peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Book of Isaiah, chapter 40*

Sonnie Swenston

For these words of hope from the ancestors,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One,
you beckon us in this season of Advent
to the dance of hope and new life -
but we who wait in these days
find ourselves
in the midst of a world
filled with hearts of stone.

In these days, it is hard to sense the glory of Advent,
or discern the Angels' song on high,
because wherever we turn,
we observe stories
of despair, war, hate, and fear.
Terror abroad and terror around the corner
make our nights long, and our days longer.

*It is too much, O God,
so we become desensitized
in an attempt to drown out
a world that feels like it is falling apart.*

Silence

Yet...we who wait know, O God,
deep within our spirits
the wisdom of the ages.
The wisdom that reminds us
we must heighten our senses
in order to find:
*your hope amid despair,
your peace amid war,
your joy amid fear,
your love amid hate.*

This morning, we who wait, O God,
ask you to inhabit our senses
that we may be a blessing
as we journey through these days of Advent.

*Help us in these days, Eternal One,
to remember that from beginning to end,
you are the God of hope, peace, joy, and love,
and that nothing in this world lies outside
the circle of your grace.*

With gratitude and in faith,
we offer this and all the prayers of our hearts.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"One Sweet Little Baby"
Cathedral Choir

GLENN MCCLURE & WES KENNISON,
arr. SHAWN KIRCHNER

Sermon

An Enduring Advent ~ Hope

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Domke

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Venite, Venite"
Rohan Ramanan and Laurel Irene, Soloists

CLAUDIO MONTEVERDI

*"Come to the holy waters all who thirst. Those who are hurting and poor,
make haste to drink of God's boundless promise." ~Isaiah 55*

***Advent Doxology**

THE FIRST NOEL

Praise God from whom all blessings flow
Praise God all creatures here below
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts
Praise Creator, Redeemer and Holy Ghost
Noël, Noël, Noël, Noël
Jesus is born, let us sing Noël.

***Prayer of Offering**

Sonnie Swenston

Faithful God, we thank you that when we journey with you
on this path of faith, we do not journey alone.

We thank you for all those who have, through the centuries,
walked this way before us,
acting in courage and seeking your ways.

We thank you for all those who travel with us today,
helping us to be for each other your hope and strength.

*Renew our wisdom and courage for the living of these days,
through the grace and goodness of your Divine Presence,
both this day and in all the days to come.
Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Advent Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Hope is our message, our witness, and our vision.
It is what we are called to share.
It is why the Spirit of the Divine brought love into our hearts.
It is the tool entrusted to us to turn back the night
and let the light shine into the shadows.

Hope is endlessly renewable.
It is the self-sustaining, perpetual motion machine of faith.
It keeps opening more doors, lifting up more opportunities,
encouraging more of us to step forward and lead.
Hope replicates itself as we reimagine the future, together.

*Holy One, we pray the new life we are creating,
will continue to recreate itself
again and again and again.
As hope draws us out and brings us forward,
we will move together -
with one heart, and one mind, and one spirit
both this day and in all the days to come.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"A la media noche"
Laude

TRADITIONAL PUERTO RICAN,
arr. DAVID GARCÍA SALDAÑA

*"At midnight, in the icy night, Jesus Christ was born, redeemer of heaven. At midnight the rooster crowed, and in his voice he said Christ has been born. His mother looks at him without being able to give a roof or cradle to rest.
Tender Child, my Jesus, you are soft and sweet, you are all love."*

*Hymn for the Journey

Come, O Long-Expected Jesus

STUTTGART

Come, O long expected Jesus, born to set all people free;
From our fears and sins release us; grant us your true liberty.

The world's strength and consolation, hope to all the earth impart;
Dear desire of every nation, enter every longing heart.

Born all people to deliver, born a child, you came to reign!
Born to love our earth forever, come, be known to us again.

By your own eternal Spirit, come to claim us as your own;
By your all sufficient merit, let us share your life on earth.
[cwesley / adptlvf]

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Postludium in C Major (Johann Christian Heinrich Rinck)

Inside The Music

"Advent is here and with it the promise of hope. We have been singing "One Sweet Little Baby" on the first Sunday of Advent for six years. It announces the beginning of the season with its bold social justice messages and hopeful determination wrapped in a light jazz swing. I was reflecting on the line "we have come so far" recently, and how it holds space for moments of progress, and challenge. Regardless of what we are going through in life, when we devote ourselves to love, each step is a journey. Isaiah's words ring throughout Advent. He prophesied the promise of a humanity governed by equity, and the

hope that people might one day wake into love and community. In the 55th chapter of Isaiah, he invites everyone, regardless of their status or station, to come to holy waters and drink deep. This is the message of Advent. We are tired. We are searching for a place to rest, and the comfort of a moment. God invites us to come to the waters of hope, peace, love, and joy as we consider the broad life-giving messages of the season. In Monteverdi's masterful vocal writing we hear the hurried steps of our wanting souls in triple time. The opening music has a slight lull to it, as if off balance, but still moving with delight at the promise. It settles finally in a duple phrase that revels in the rich delights of hope. The piece rotates between these two sections several more times before the end. Miraculously, at each return of the triple section, it feels more confident and assured, just as each return of the duple section feels sweeter. Traditionally Advent is a season of introspection and patience. As we await the coming Star, we take stock, find order in our lives, and weave gratitude through each loving action. The Puerto Rican "A la media noche" sings of the party that is to come that will surround the child that is all love. For this, we continue on, one hopeful step at a time." -Dr. David Harris